when they win and break records, but the moment their hero falters, their allegiance moves to the next rising star.

In this meet, too, my win was the result of a photo finish, the camera proving that it was my torso that hit the finishing tape first. The crowds were overjoyed, particularly the sizable Indian population that was living in Moscow, who leapt out of their seats and ran into the stadium, embracing me and lifting me up on to their shoulders with excitement.

I was interviewed by the Soviet press agencies, which asked me a series of searching questions: What were my impressions about the Soviet Union? What did I think of Indo-Soviet relations? What did the people of India think of Russia? They seemed to be fairly happy with my bland replies.

When I left Moscow for London, Nina and a few others came to the airport to see me off. I had made some good friends during my short time in the city. I continued to keep in touch with them for a while, and today, when I read their letters, I remember the good times we had together all those years ago. For years I had corresponded with many other friends, admirers, and even strangers, who had entered my life at some time or the other. For me, meeting new people, befriending them and then parting was a normal part of the interactions I’ve had with a large number of strangers over the years. Yet, for me, establishing contact with my fans was of the greatest importance.